

## Carron Creates Clarity

### THE FULL PLAN

# The 90-Day Owner-Independence Test

The real question isn't "can I take a holiday?" It is: can the business make routine decisions, serve customers, collect cash, pay obligations, manage people, resolve problems and protect itself for 90 days — without relying on the owner's knowledge, authority, relationships or presence?

Framed that way, this stops being a leave planner and becomes a measure of business maturity, resilience, scalability and — ultimately — saleability. A buyer pays for a business that runs; not for a job that depends on you.

**The one test that matters.** For every item, don't ask "do I do this?" — ask "can this happen without me?"

### YOUR SCORE

## What your 90-Day Test score means

| Score  | Label             | What it tells you                                                              |
|--------|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0–39   | Self-Employed     | The business is you — an unplanned week away would already cause problems.     |
| 40–64  | Owner-Reliant     | It runs, but leans on you for approvals; it could cope for a few days, not 90. |
| 65–84  | Owner-Light       | Strong foundations — could hold for a few weeks. Close the remaining gaps.     |
| 85–100 | Owner-Independent | A business, not a job. Decisions happen without you, up to clear limits.       |

### THE METHOD

## Score maturity, not paperwork

A ticked box that says "an SOP exists" proves nothing. Score every item on how far it has actually travelled from you:

| Level | State           | Meaning                                                  |
|-------|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 0     | Owner-dependent | Nobody else can do it.                                   |
| 1     | Documented      | The process or authority exists on paper.                |
| 2     | Delegated       | Another named person is trained and authorised.          |
| 3     | Proven          | They have actually done it, without you, more than once. |

**RAG per area:** Red (avg < 1.0) — still owner-dependent, fix first. Amber (1.0–1.9) — on paper or partly delegated, not yet safe. Green (2.0+) — delegated, heading to proven. **Proven beats documented every time.**

## THE SPINE

**The Authority Matrix (build this first)**

For every recurring decision, answer four questions — not just “who has authority”: **Who can decide?** → **Up to what limit?** → **What must be documented?** → **When must it escalate?** And add the column most matrices miss — **Reserved Matters**: decisions that should never simply fall to whoever is on duty.

| Decision        | Authority       | Limit    | Escalate to   | Reserved?   |
|-----------------|-----------------|----------|---------------|-------------|
| Customer refund | Service Manager | R10,000  | GM            | No          |
| Sales discount  | Sales Manager   | 7.5%     | GM            | No          |
| Capex           | GM              | R100,000 | Owner / Board | Above limit |
| New borrowing   | —               | —        | Owner / Board | <b>Yes</b>  |

Reserved Matters typically include substantial debt, a major or long-term contract, buying or selling a major asset, settling material litigation, changing shareholder arrangements, unusually large capex, changing banking facilities, and hiring or firing very senior people.

**No new single point of failure.** Removing dependence on the owner must not simply create dependence on the deputy. Every business-critical responsibility needs a primary owner and a capable backup.

## SURVIVE FIRST

**Part A — the 10 that decide whether you survive 90 days at all**

If any one still requires you, the business stalls within days. Aim for all ten at level 3 before any real absence.

- **1. Authority Matrix exists** — who can decide/spend/approve/discount/refund/hire/extend credit, to what limit, what's logged, when it escalates, which matters are reserved.
- **2. Payments can be released without you** — payroll and suppliers up to a set limit.
- **3. A sale can be closed without you** — quote, discount within rules, accept an order.
- **4. A customer problem can be resolved without you** — complaint + refund/credit to a limit.
- **5. Stock/supplies can be reordered without you** — raise a PO, approve a supplier invoice to a limit.
- **6. People matters can be handled without you** — leave, a shift gap, minor discipline.
- **7. Authorised access survives without you** — no critical system depends on your personal login, device or MFA; named accounts, banking mandates, password-manager emergency access, backup MFA.
- **8. Escalation works** — including when you can't be reached — what genuinely needs you, a way to reach you, and a predefined emergency authority for when you're unreachable.
- **9. A weekly numbers rhythm** — a short exception scorecard the team runs without you.
- **10. Cash keeps coming in without you** — someone owns debtor follow-up: enforce terms, place on stop, negotiate an approved arrangement, escalate material overdue accounts.

## RUN WELL

**Part B — the full 40-question assessment**

The 20-question test you took online is the short version — two questions per dimension. This is the complete assessment: **four questions for each of the ten dimensions**. Score every question **0–3** using the maturity

scale above (0 = owner-dependent, 3 = proven) by circling a number. Add up your total (out of 120), then divide by 120 and multiply by 100 for your owner-independence score — and read it against the band table on page 1.

### 1. Decision Rights & Authority

|                                                                                                                                   |   |   |   |   |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Is there an authority matrix — who can approve what (spend, discount, refund, credit, hire), to what Rand limit — without you? | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 2. Is there a named deputy who holds authority when you're away, with a capable backup for the deputy?                            | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 3. Does everyone know what they can decide alone versus what must escalate — with no guessing?                                    | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 4. Is there a rule for the unknown case, and are Reserved Matters defined (major debt, contracts, senior hires)?                  | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |

### 2. Sales, Quoting & Pricing

|                                                                                                      |   |   |   |   |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|
| 5. Can someone quote, apply a discount within set rules, and close a sale without checking with you? | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 6. Do pre-approved quote, contract and terms templates exist so nobody rebuilds them each time?      | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 7. Is there a rule for accepting a new customer (credit terms, deposit) without your sign-off?       | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 8. Is the pipeline visible in a shared place, and does someone own lead follow-up while you're away? | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |

### 3. Customer Service & Resolution

|                                                                                                         |   |   |   |   |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|
| 9. Can someone resolve a complaint and issue a refund or credit up to a limit without you?              | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 10. Are key customer relationships known to more than one person (not only you)?                        | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 11. Is there a documented complaints policy with an escalation path to the deputy, not straight to you? | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 12. Is there a response-time standard (e.g. every customer gets a reply within 24 hours)?               | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |

### 4. Collections & Credit Control

|                                                                                                              |   |   |   |   |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|
| 13. Does someone own debtor follow-up — enforce terms, place an account on stop, escalate — without you?     | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 14. Can credit limits, changes to payment terms and repayment arrangements be approved to rules without you? | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 15. Is the amount and age at which overdue debt escalates clearly defined?                                   | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 16. Can someone tell you the overdue and aged-debtor position at any time?                                   | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |

### 5. Money & Payments

|                                                                                                  |   |   |   |   |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|
| 17. Can someone approve and release payroll and supplier payments up to a limit without you?     | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 18. Does a second person hold a banking mandate and know the cash position at any time?          | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 19. Are expense and purchase approvals delegated with clear per-role limits?                     | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 20. Is there a rule for who decides, when cash is tight, which payments defer and in what order? | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |

## 6. Purchasing & Suppliers

|                                                                                                   |   |   |   |   |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|
| 21. Can staff reorder stock, raise a purchase order and approve a supplier invoice up to a limit? | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 22. Are the preferred-supplier list, terms and contacts known to more than one person?            | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 23. Are documented reorder rules in place (what to reorder, when, how much)?                      | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 24. Is there a process for a supplier problem (late, wrong, price change) without you?            | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |

## 7. People, Operations & Delivery

|                                                                                                  |   |   |   |   |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|
| 25. Can a manager approve leave, cover a shift gap and handle first-line discipline without you? | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 26. Is the core work documented in simple SOPs with written quality standards?                   | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 27. Does every key role have a cross-trained backup — no role one-person-deep?                   | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 28. Is onboarding documented, and do recurring tasks have named owners and a schedule?           | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |

## 8. Access, IT & Cyber Resilience

|                                                                                                                         |   |   |   |   |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|
| 29. Is access free of your personal login, device or MFA — named accounts, mandates, password-manager emergency access? | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 30. Is there a written IT/cyber incident plan (outage, ransomware, lost phone, failed backup, payment fraud)?           | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 31. Are premises keys, alarm codes, key contracts, insurance and licences held or stored where the team can reach them? | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 32. Are backups tested, and is it clear who authorises spend and who tells customers during an incident?                | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |

## 9. Compliance & Obligations

|                                                                                                   |   |   |   |   |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|
| 33. Do tax and statutory submissions happen without you?                                          | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 34. Are insurance renewals, licences and permits diarised and owned, with a backup?               | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 35. Are contract renewal and notice dates tracked so nothing lapses unnoticed?                    | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 36. Does someone know which events must be reported to insurers, regulators, lenders or partners? | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |

## 10. Rhythm, Escalation & Continuity

|                                                                                                           |   |   |   |   |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|
| 37. Does a weekly exception scorecard (cash, sales, margin, delivery, people, risk) run, led by the team? | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 38. Is there a clear escalation path, including an emergency authority if you're unreachable?             | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 39. Are there clear targets so the team knows what 'on track' looks like without asking you?              | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 40. Has the team practised a real owner-absence — a week with the phone off — and fixed what broke?       | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 |

## HIDDEN DEPENDENCE

## External relationships

Owner-dependence often hides in relationships, not processes. For each of these, is the history known to more than one person, and is someone other than you authorised to deal with them? **Bank** · **accountant/auditor** · **lawyer** · **insurance broker** · **landlord** · **major funder** · **key technology provider** · **outsourced payroll** · **major strategic partner**.

### THE RHYTHM

## The weekly scorecard (an exception dashboard, not a management pack)

| Area     | What it answers                                                        |
|----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Cash     | Bank/cash available · near-term cash requirement · overdue receivables |
| Revenue  | Sales / order intake · pipeline or backlog                             |
| Margin   | Gross margin / contribution                                            |
| Delivery | Orders / jobs / projects overdue                                       |
| People   | Serious staffing issues                                                |
| Risk     | Major customer, supplier or quality incidents                          |

### THE PROOF

## The real test (and how to record it)

The progression stays: one week → two weeks → one month → 90 days, each with your phone off. But don't just note what broke — every time you're absent, record three things:

| Symptom                        | What it reveals                |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| What <b>stopped</b> ?          | A process / capability failure |
| What <b>waited</b> ?           | An authority failure           |
| What <b>came back to you</b> ? | A delegation / culture failure |

**The brutal rule:** if the owner answers a question that someone else should have been able to answer, the test failed at that point. Otherwise owners quietly keep rescuing the business and wrongly conclude it passed.

Owner: \_\_\_\_\_ Deputy: \_\_\_\_\_ Deputy's backup: \_\_\_\_\_ Date: \_\_\_\_\_

General management framework; not accounting, tax, legal or other professional advice specific to your business.